Thailand's EV duties target Chinese imports

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【要点】

・タイ内閣は2027年1月から輸入電気自動車の物品税を10～15%から35%に引き上げることを承認し、急増する中国製EV輸入の抑制を狙っている。

・タイの中流階級に人気のあるEVがこれまで標的にされなかったが、国内自動車産業への悪影響が政治的な懸念となり、今回の措置につながった。

・インドネシアとマレーシアも同様の措置を検討する可能性があるが、タイが域内最大の自動車生産ハブのため影響が最も大きい。

・タイが国を特定せず物品税として導入したため、中国からの報復リスクは低く、貿易協定違反の可能性も少ないと考えられる。

・中国の主要EV企業の一部はすでにタイで生産を開始しており、北京はタイを重要な自動車投資先と見なしている。

【メール原文】

EV duties reflect intensifying concerns about Chinese imports and domestic production push.‌‌‌‌‌‌‌‌‌‌‌‌‌‌‌‌

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Thailand’s EV duties mark intensifying pushback against Chinese imports

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What Happened

Thailand’s cabinet approved a proposal to increase excise duties on imported fully assembled battery electric vehicles (BEVs) and range-extended electric vehicles (REEVs) to 35% from 1 January 2027. BEVs and REEVs are currently taxed at 10% and 15%.

Our Take

EV duties reflect intensifying concerns about Chinese imports and domestic production push. While the Thai government has not named China and the excise duties will apply to vehicles imported from any country, surging Chinese EV imports are clearly the intended target.

There have been growing concerns, as previously reported, in Thailand and elsewhere in ASEAN about surging Chinese imports. Earlier this year, a prominent Thai think tank labeled Chinese imports as a greater risk than US tariffs for Thai firms (perhaps reflecting the domestic focus of many local companies). Thailand—and its regional peers—have largely focused on stemming the flow of low-cost consumer goods (including via e-commerce platforms) and strategic items such as steel. EVs had not

previously been targeted as they are popular with the middle class and governments worried about antagonizing Beijing, but the damage to Thailand's domestic auto industry has become a growing political concern.

Indonesia and Malaysia could also further tighten EV policies, though concerns are less acute. Governments in both countries have already chosen not to extend now-lapsed incentives and exemptions for fully imported EVs, though have not yet gone as far as Thailand in terms of raising barriers. As the largest automotive production hub in ASEAN, Thailand has the most to lose.

Indonesia might consider similar steps if EV imports continue to rise (Indonesia imported more Chinese EVs last year than Thailand did); Jakarta is similarly keen to promote more local production. Meanwhile, Malaysia notably let its EV exemptions (for fully imported units) lapse after its government-linked car companies launched their own EV models, and with Prime Minister Anwar Ibrahim keen to be seen supporting domestic industry and jobs ahead of general elections expected in late 2027.

Risk of retaliation by Beijing is modest. Thailand did not name China and the duties apply to imports from any country. As the changes are to excise duties rather than import tariffs, Bangkok's new policy seems unlikely to fall foul of its market access commitments in the China-ASEAN Free Trade Agreement and Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership. This also applies to ASEAN's internal trade deal and other FTAs. Several key Chinese EV makers have already started production in Thailand and Beijing already sees the country as an important automotive investment destination and is unlikely to retaliate. Nevertheless, China will be aware that its EVs are the main target and could take some minor steps against Thailand, such as trade investigations.

Meanwhile, Thailand's measures on EV imports may be positively noted by the US ahead of the expected conclusion soon of a bilateral trade deal, but Bangkok's motivations were primarily domestic. Higher excise duties on imported EVs will also be welcomed by Japanese carmakers that have long-established production bases in Thailand.

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